

USING MATCHUP DATA AND PHASE-WISE SCORING PATTERNS, THIS ANALYSIS IDENTIFIES HIDDEN BATTING VULNERABILITIES AND MAKES THE CASE FOR A PLAYING XI BUILT TO SOLVE TACTICAL PROBLEMS.

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India, which begins its title defence of the Men's T20 World Cup in a week, is being touted as the favourite. While its middle order has endured a fallow period in recent times, its gung-ho opener and varied bowling options, including Jasprit Bumrah and Varun Chakaravathy, give it a massive edge. Here, I present an analyst's perspective on the potential weaknesses in India's batting line-up, in addition to arguing for its optimal playing XI.

Very little needs to be said about the juggernaut that is Abhishek Sharma. He has addressed his weaknesses against good and hard-length pace by expanding his shot range and moving around effectively at the crease. Tracking data shows that the range of his

impact points against good and hard-length pace has expanded significantly. As a result, his strike rate (SR) against the 6-10 m length while facing pace has gone up from 113 in the 2022-23 IPL to 162 in 2024-25. For reference, the average batter struck the same lengths at 124 and 139 SR in these two eras.

From being below average, Abhishek has zoomed ahead of his peers against the most common pace lengths any batter can face. The only chink in his armour could be his tendency to mistime balls wide outside the off stump, a weakness that teams have recently